

Startup Barriers Collapsing: The One-Person Company

It now takes fewer people, and less time, to build something big

Unicorn Comparison

AI unicorns (2024)

~200

employees

~2 yrs

to reach \$1B

2x

4.5x

Traditional unicorns

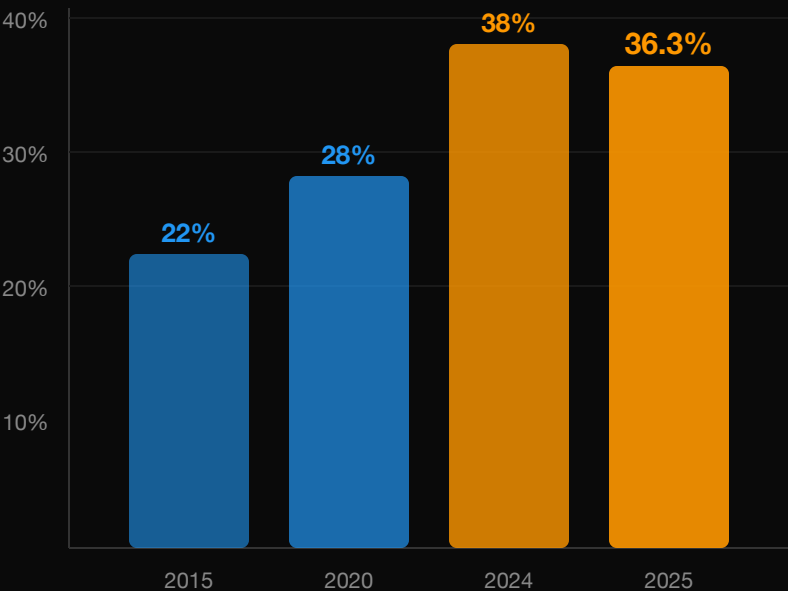
~400

employees

~9 yrs

to reach \$1B

Solo Founder Share



Historical Parallel: Every Drop in Barriers Triggers a Boom

1990s Web → e-commerce

2007 iPhone → mobile economy

2010s Cloud → SaaS boom

2025 AI → solo founders

YC Winter 2025: 10%/week aggregate growth — Garry Tan calls it YC's fastest-growing batch ever

Getting laid off ≠ downgrading to Uber · Experience + AI = the output of a 20-person team

The barrier to starting something has never been lower, and the leverage has never been higher.